

**Mapping Siberia, Imagining Russia: Ian Frazier's Travels in Siberia and the Persistence of
Western Mental Geography**

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Ian Frazier's two 2009 *New Yorker* essays, "Travels in Siberia I" and "Travels in Siberia II", present as curious, yet humorous, accounts of a lengthy journey across the east of Russia.¹ At a surface level, these are simple travel journal entries, detailing roads, cities, and conversations. However, when read through the perspectives of particular Enlightenment political theorist Jean-Jacques Rousseau and 19th-century travel writers such as Astolphe de Custine and Adam Olearius, Frazier's essays appear less isolated and more continuous with a longstanding Western tradition of imagining Russia through space. As scholars of "mental geography" such as Mark Bassin have argued, Russia has been conceptualised not simply as a region of land, but also as an idea, whose vastness, climate, and peripheral position are viewed as explanatory of its own destiny and the character of those inhabiting it.² Read through this framework, Frazier's Siberia becomes more than a set of retold stories; it engages, whether intentionally or otherwise, in a historical, inherited habit of regarding Russia as geographic and a civilisational concept. The shift from Rousseau's political theory and Custine's moral alarm to Frazier's sardonic curiosity signifies a change of tone, but not necessarily a change of structure when it comes to Russia's interpretation by Westerners.

A striking feature of Frazier's Siberia is scale. He presents this region as more than just "large", instead rendering it overwhelming in its size, almost resistant to comprehension. Distances stretch on endlessly, roads dissolve into monotony, and settlements seem as though suspended within a bleak expanse, dwarfing any effort by humans to tame the beast.³ What is emerging already is not a simple description by Frazier, but rather, what is identified as a type of

¹ Ian Frazier, "Travels in Siberia: The Ultimate Road Trip," *The New Yorker*, July 27, 2009, <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2009/08/03/travels-in-siberia-i>; Ian Frazier, "Travels in Siberia-II," *The New Yorker*, August 3, 2009, <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2009/08/10/travels-in-siberia-ii>

² Mark Bassin, "Russia between Europe and Asia: The Ideological Construction of Geographical Space," *Slavic Review* 50, no. 1 (Spring 1991): 1–17, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2500595>

³ Frazier, "Travels in Siberia: The Ultimate Road Trip,"; Frazier, "Travels in Siberia-II."

mental mapping by Bassin, one where space has become imbued with interpretive meaning.⁴ Russia becomes synonymous with immensity. Siberia is this testing ground for human endurance; it is a space where ordinary measures are irrelevant, even inadequate. Frazier doesn't explicitly advance any theory of national character, though his descriptive choices do suggest that those who live within such spaces as Siberia are subsequently shaped by it. Bassin argues that Western depictions of Russia have historically connected physical space with the trajectory of a civilisation, translating geography to destiny.⁵ Frazier's Siberia matches this pattern, even if in an implicit manner. And so, traits of resilience, stoicism, and adaptability despite pressure appear as responses to geography.

The bridge between land and social or political development calls back arguments within Rousseau's *Social Contract*. Within Book II, Chapter VIII, Rousseau asserts that laws must suit the soil, climate, and historical maturity of a particular people.⁶ His claim that Russia was governed "too early" rests upon this geographic determinism.⁷ Though Frazier is not writing as a political theorist, this structural logic remains. Harsh, long winters and extended isolation become formative forces, rather than a neutral background; environment, in essence, becomes an explanation.

Siberia's historical association with exile and punishment buffs this continuity, with the Gulag never being quite out of sight in Frazier's accounts.⁸ This remains the case, even when describing contemporary towns and cities or everyday conversations, with a memory seemingly overlaying the landscape itself. Vastness becomes associated with concealment, suffering, and the State's power. For Custine, the empire's size enabled isolation, surveillance, and political

⁴ Bassin, "Russia between Europe and Asia."

⁵ Bassin, "Russia between Europe and Asia."

⁶ Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract and the First and Second Discourses* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2002) 183–85."

⁷ Jean-Jacques Rousseau, 183–185

⁸ Frazier, "Travels in Siberia: The Ultimate Road Trip"; Frazier, "Travels in Siberia–II."

passivity.⁹ In *Letters from Russia*, he argues that Russia's vast distances and dispersed population made a collective resistance near impossible. Individuals, being separated from one another both physically and socially, allowed the autocratic state to be the only force binding society together. In his account, immensity didn't only describe the land, but also protected despotism, fragmenting the populace and rendering political action unable to occur.¹⁰ Frazier doesn't replicate Custine's moral urgency, but he does note, repeatedly, how remoteness shapes the relationship between the people and the State. Distance from administrative centers, limited infrastructure, and harsh climate instill resignation and pragmatic endurance, rather than motivating a collective mobilisation.

That said, there are differences between the tone and declared purpose. Custine arrived with ideological intentions and left with a condemnation of autocratic rule. His accounts were diagnostic, polemical. Frazier's were exploratory. His audience was that of the American citizen, one who imagines Siberia as a blank space on a map. His objective was description, changing that space from blank with anecdotes and observations. Frazier acknowledges the limits of his understanding, and his use of humour also undercuts any potential claim to be the authority on the topic of Siberia. Yet even in this lighter register, older patterns remain. Similar to older travellers, Frazier structures his accounts around movement. His journey provides coherence; individual encounters become representative, whether it be a driver, a guide, or a historian; they all stand for something bigger. This transition from anecdote to implication is a subtle one, but it adds up throughout. The continuous emphasis on toughness, dark humour, or fatalism merges into an image of "Russian character." Essentialism is avoided explicitly, but suggestion still performs much of the same exact work.

⁹ Astolphe de Custine, *Letters from Russia* (New York: New York Review Books, 2002), 46–48.

¹⁰ Astolphe de Custine, 46–48

Imagined geography also operates through framing Siberia as a periphery. From a Western perspective, it seems to be the ultimate Margin, distant from power and cultural centres alike. Simultaneously, in Russian history, Siberia has, in fact, been a location of expansion and resource acquisition, making it rather integral to the ambitions of a growing imperium. Frazier occasionally makes gestures toward this internal perspective, though the dominant framing remains Western in its nature. Bassin notes that Russia has been positioned within European discourse as both inside and outside Europe; concurrently familiar, yet alien.¹¹ Frazier's Siberia occupies this liminal space, being modern, yet archaic, developed, though incredibly remote. The Enlightenment debates about Russia's placement between Europe and Asia are echoed through this portrayal. Rousseau saw a nation out of step with Europe's development.¹² Custine portrays it as a distorted reflection of Europe. Frazier's accounts, however, retain the tension, though now stripped of polemic.

Frazier's existence as a foreign observer supports this structure. He is dependent on guides and translators, and his time in each location is episodic, particularly immersive or drawn-out.¹³ Russia becomes an object for narration, while Western consciousness sets the frame.¹⁴ The gaze shifts, by and large, in one direction. And even when Frazier is expressing admiration or sympathy, the structure of observation continues.

Reading Frazier's essays with Rousseau and Custine's writings in mind doesn't necessarily reveal repetition, per se, though it can be viewed as adaptation. The tone itself has shifted; Frazier's curiosity has replaced moral alarm. However, the tropes of massive spaces,

¹¹ Bassin, "Russia between Europe and Asia."

¹² Rousseau, 183.

¹³ Frazier, "Travels in Siberia: The Ultimate Road Trip"; Frazier, "Travels in Siberia-II."

¹⁴ Adam Olearius, *The Travels of Olearius in Seventeenth-Century Russia*, ed. and trans. Samuel H. Baron (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1967).

unforgiving climate, political extremism, and the character of Russians, as a people, remain throughout.¹⁵ Geography persists as a predictor of destiny.

Recognising these features does not devalue Frazier's accounts, as his attention to detail, with individual voices and general reluctance to draw sweeping conclusions, adds nuance otherwise absent from earlier writers. This said, his accounts show how spatial framing matters. As Bassin suggests, imagined geographies shape political and cultural understanding long after their origins disappear from view.¹⁶ When Western narratives consistently link Russian space to authoritarianism, extremity, or historical inevitability, they also risk naturalising what are, in fact, contingent political conditions. Identifying this pattern enables one to see how contemporary journalism participates in longstanding interpretive traditions. The significance lies not in pointing fingers at Frazier and screaming "imitation!", but rather in understanding how Western perceptions of Russia persist in being structured through spatial metaphors. Mental geography is active, not as an obvious ideology, but as a subtle architecture underpinning the descriptions of contemporary journalists.

¹⁵ Frazier, "Travels in Siberia"; Custine, *Letters from Russia*.

¹⁶ Bassin, "Russia between Europe and Asia."

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